THE TATTVAYOGABINDU OF RĀMACANDRA

Critical Edition and Annotated Translation of an Early Modern Text on Rājayoga, with a Comparative Analysis of the Complex Yoga Taxonomies from the Same Period



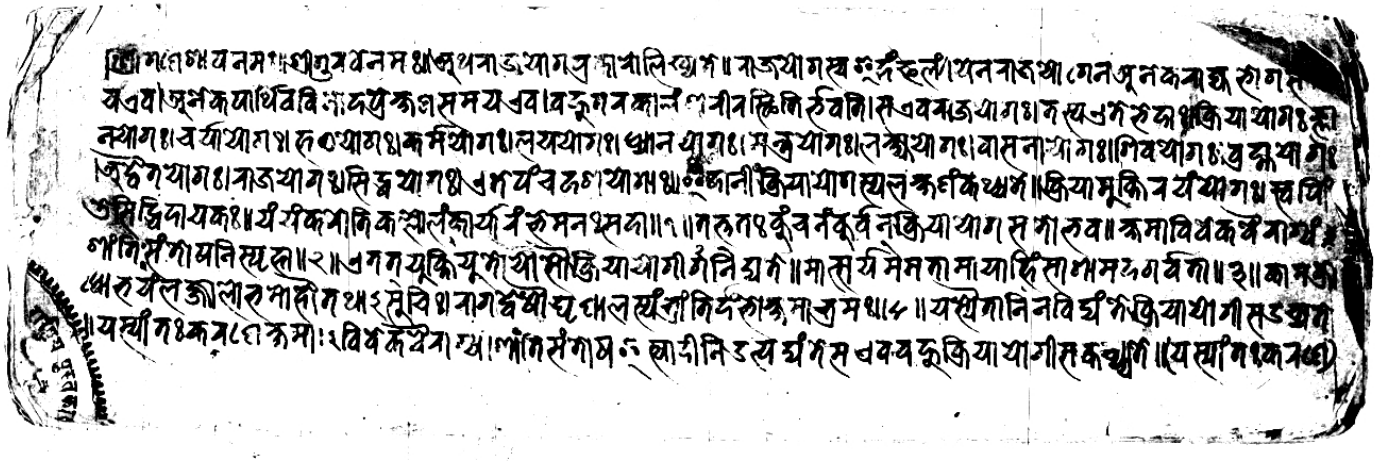


Figure 1: Folio IV of Ms. N_1.

Contents

Contents v

List of Figures vii

List of Tables viii

1 Critical Edition & Annotated Translation of the *Tattvayogabindu* 1

1.1 Lakṣyayoga 2

1.1.1 Lakṣyayoga in the *Tattvayogabindu*, *Yogasvarodaya* and *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 5

1.1.1.1 Ūrdhvalakṣya 6

1.1.1.2 Adholakṣya 7

1.1.1.3 Bāhyalakṣya 9

1.1.1.4 Antar(a)lakṣya 11

1.1.1.5 Madhyalakṣya 14

1.1.2 Lakṣyayoga in the *Yogasiddhāntacandrikā* 15

1.1.3 Lakṣyayoga in the complex yoga taxonomies 17

2 Appendix 19

2.1 Figures 19

3 Bibliography 23

Primary Sources 25

Secondary Literature 26

Index 27

Index **27**

List of Figures

1 Folio 1v of Ms. N_1. iii

2 The *dehasvarūpa* of *ajapāgāyatrī* 20

3 Viṣṇu Viśvarūpa, India, Rajasthan, Jaipur, ca. 1800–1820, Opaque watercolor and gold on paper, 38.5 × 28 cm, Victoria and Albert Museum, London, Given by Mrs. Gerald Clark. 21

4 The Equivalence of Self and Universe (detail), folio 6 from the *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati* (Bulaki), India, Rajasthan, Jodhpur, 1824 (Samvat 1881), 122 x 46 cm, RJS 2378, Mehragarh Museum Trust. 22

List of Tables

1 Foci of Bāhyalakṣya 10

Chapter 1

The *Tattvayogabindu* of Rāmacandra

Critical Edition & Annotated Translation

1.1 Lakṣyayoga

LAKṢYAYOGA, the "Yoga of foci", is one of the most extensive and important topics[1] in the *Tattvayogabindu*.[2] The concept of this type of yoga has a complex history of reception, and its origins as a category of specific yoga techniques can be traced back to early Tantric texts.

The yoga practice of *lakṣya*s derives from an ancient Śaiva paradigm. The origins of this paradigm are difficult to reconstruct precisely. In many cases, the *lakṣya*s are taught together with a system of six to nine *cakra*s, sixteen *ādhāra*s and five *vyoma*s, *ākāśa*s or *kha*s. In most texts that take up this paradigm, there is a variant of a verse also contained in the *Tattvayogabindu*, which lists the elements just mentioned as essential components of yoga.[3] Perhaps the earliest datable textual evidence for the practice of yogic *lakṣya*s can be found in *Netratantra* 7.1–2, which was composed between 700–850 CE.[4] Here, the *lakṣya*s are only listed but not explained in detail, suggesting that the practice may be older than the *Netratantra* itself. Kṣemarāja, in his *Netroddyota* commentary, further elaborates on the three *lakṣya*s. Enveloped in enigmatic language, he briefly states in the context of *Netratantra* 7.27:

> *trīṇy antarbahirubhayarūpāṇi lakṣyāṇi lakṣaṇīyāni yatra* |
> *nirāvaraṇarūpatvāt "khamanantaṃ tu janmākhyaṃ"*|
>
> The three foci, internal, external or both, are to be attained, and because they are unobstructed, "The endless void is called the birth."

[1] In the *Śivayogapradīpikā* 1.8, the one who has attained the realisation of Brahman using the (in this case) three *lakṣya*s is called a knower of Rājayoga. In this text, the practice of *lakṣya*s is the primary characteristic practice of Rājayoga. In addition, being free from mental fluctuation through gnosis is specified as the second characteristic practice: *triṣu lakṣyeṣu yo brahmasākṣātkāraṃ gamiṣyati* | *jñāne vātha manovṛttirahito rājayogavit* ‖ 1.8 ‖

[2] The sections XIII (overview of the five *lakṣya*s), XIV (*adholakṣya*), XV (*ūrdhvalakṣya*), XXIII (*bāhyalakṣya*), XXIV (*antaralakṣya*) and XXVII (*madhyalakṣya*) of the *Tattvayogabindu* deal exclusively with the types of Lakṣyayoga.

[3] See *Tattvayogabindu* section XXVIII.1 for the verse and its variants in other contemporary and earlier texts.

[4] Sanderson, 2004: 243.

After this, the *lakṣya*s are not mentioned explicitly. Yet *Netratantra* 8.39–44 clearly alludes to *lakṣya* techniques: the yogin, already in *samādhi*, is instructed to abandon meditation on various focal points. The rejected foci closely parallel the three to five *lakṣya*s found in early modern yoga taxonomies. For example, *Netratantra* 8.42 states:

> *nāntaḥ śarīrasaṃsthāne na bāhye bhāvayet kvacit* |
> *nākāśe bandhayel lakṣyaṃ nādho dṛṣṭiṃ niveśayet* ‖ 42 ‖
>
> One should not contemplate any place of the body inside or outside. One should not fix one's attention on the sky (open space), nor should one direct one's gaze downwards.[5]

The *Mālinīviyajottaratantra* (12.9) and other linked Tantras[6] also contain a system of *lakṣya*s. In the *Mālinīviyajottaratantra*, there are six *lakṣya*s. These six *lakṣya*s are labelled as follows: 1. emptiness (*vyoman*), 2. body (*vigraha*), 3. drop (*bindu*), 4. phoneme (*arṇa*), 5. world (*bhuvana*) and 6. resonance (*dhvani*). According to Vasudeva (2004: 255), *lakṣyabheda* in *Mālinīviyajottaratantra* denotes "the ultimate destination upon which the Yogin must fix his attention". These *lakṣya*s are "different manifestations through which Śiva can be approached". He further states: "To the Yogin engaged in the conquest of realities the *lakṣya*s serve as teleological magnets drawing him towards the desired rewards". Despite the same basic concept, the *lakṣya*s of the *Mālinīviyajottaratantra* appear very different at first glance. On closer inspection, however, there are striking parallels with the *lakṣya* systems found in the late medieval texts treated in this chapter. For example, the first *lakṣya* of the *Mālinīviyajottaratantra* 12.10abc is described as follows:

> *bāhyābhyantarabhedena samuccayakṛtena ca trividhaṃ kīrtitaṃ vyoma* |
>
> The void is said to be threefold by the division of external, internal and that arising from accumulation.

[5] Additionally, cf. *Netratantra* 8.44ab.
[6] E.g. *Kiraṇatantra* 2.22–23 and *Dīkṣottara* 2.2–3.

Vasudeva (2004: 263) maintains that this elliptical definition can only be explained on the basis of the teachings on the voids of other Śaiva Tantras but notes that none of the systems he consulted show complete congruence with the position of the *Mālinīviyajottaratantra*. Nevertheless, he cites, for example, the passages from *Dīkṣottara* 3.10c–11 and *Svacchandatantra* 4.289 that are particularly relevant here, in which an upper emptiness (*ūrdhvaśūnya*), a lower emptiness (*adhaḥśūnya*) and a middle emptiness (*madhyaśūnya*) are distinguished.

Taken together, the basic features of the late medieval differentiation of the five *lakṣya*s into *ūrdhva-*, *adho-*, *bāhya-*, *antara-*, and *madhyalakṣya* can already be discerned here.[7] This rough overview illustrates that different systems of yogic *lakṣya* practices circulated in Śaiva Tantric traditions over a long period. Over the centuries, the techniques were transmitted, adapted, and reused in the yoga traditions of Haṭha- and Rājayoga.

In addition to the four texts analysed in this chapter, different forms of *lakṣya* practice are also found in *Vivekamārtaṇḍa*, *Śivayogapradīpikā*, (recensions of the *Haṭhapradīpikā*), *Yogasvarodaya*, *Nityanāthapaddhati*, *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati*, *Yogacūḍāmaṇyupaniṣad*, *Maṇḍalabrāhmaṇopaniṣat*, *Haṭhatattvakaumudī* and *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā*. However, Lakṣyayoga was not labelled as an independent yoga category until the texts of the complex late medieval yoga taxonomies emerged. In the fifteen-fold yoga taxonomy of the *Tattvayogabindu*, Lakṣyayoga is listed as the ninth method of Rājayoga. The *Yogasvarodaya* does not mention Lakṣyayoga in its introductory verses. The *Yogasvarodaya* dedicates two verses to listing the fifteen yogas. Although the verses announce fifteen yogas, only eight yogas are specified, probably for metrical reasons. Lakṣyayoga is not among the eight yogas mentioned but is dealt with in detail throughout the text. In the *Yogasiddhāntacandrikā*, Lakṣyayoga is the eighth yoga method mentioned by Nārāyaṇatīrtha.[8] Within the *Sarvāṅ-*

[7] The *lakṣya*s of the *Mālinīviyajottaratantra* are discussed in detail in Vasudeva, 2004: 253–293.

[8] For an earlier discussion of *Lakṣyayoga* in the *Yogasiddhāntacandrikā*, see Penna, 2004: 77–78.

gayogapradīpikā Sundardās presents Lakṣayoga[9] as one of the four methods of Haṭhayoga alongside Rājayoga and Aṣṭāṅgayoga.[10] In contrast to the yoga categories discussed so far, Lakṣyayoga is conceptually largely congruent within the late medieval texts of the complex yoga taxonomies and differs only in a few details.

1.1.1 Lakṣyayoga in the *Tattvayogabindu*, *Yogasvarodaya* and *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā*

The three texts present Lakṣyayoga as an explicitly simple form of yoga right at the beginning of their respective discourses. The descriptions of the texts are very similar in most respects. Thus, a separate analysis of them, as in the previous chapters, would be redundant. The word *lakṣya* means "goal". In the practice of Lakṣyayoga, it refers to goals on which the gaze (*dṛṣṭi*) and the mind are directed, i.e. a "focus" for stabilising the mind on which one constantly meditates. The three texts distinguish five categories from one another, depending on the location on which attention is focused. The following order[11] is given in the *Tattvayogabindu* and *Yogasvarodaya*: 1. the upper focus (*ūrdhvalakṣya*), 2. the lower focus (*adholakṣya*), 3. the outer focus (*bāhyalakṣya*), 4. the middle focus (*madhyalakṣya*) and 5. the inner focus (*antar(a)lakṣya*).[12,13] Meditation on particular focal points is said to produce specific results.

[9] The terms vary in the literature. The most common term is *lakṣya*, but *lakṣa* or *lakṣana* were also commonly specified.

[10] See Burger (2014: 697–98) for another discussion of Lakṣayoga in the *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* in French.

[11] The order in the *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* is not identical, but as follows: 1. *adho lakṣa*, 2. *ūrddha lakṣa*, 3. *madhya lakṣa*, 4. *bāhya lakṣa* and 5. *aṃtar lakṣa*.

[12] Only in *Tattvayogabindu* is this *lakṣya* is designated as *antaralakṣya*. In all other texts, including the *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā*, which quotes the *Tattvayogabindu*, the term *antarlakṣya* is used.

[13] In the *Tattvayogabindu* section XIII, in the *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, Ed. pp. 833–834) and *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 3.25–36.

1.1.1.1 Ūrdhvalakṣya

In the *Tattvayogabindu* and *Yogasvarodaya*, the upper focus (*ūrdhvalakṣya*)[14] consists in fixing the gaze (*dṛṣṭi*) and the mind (*manas*) on the centre of the sky, or the zenith (*ākāśamadhye*). This results in the unity of the gaze with the splendour of the Supreme God (*parameśvara*). In addition, an object appears in the sky within the practitioner's field of vision, an object that was previously unseen.[15] The latter effect is cryptic. The source text, the *Yogasvarodaya*, offers no clarification in this case, as there is no parallel passage. The *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā*[16] quotes this passage verbatim, without further explanation. The only clue lies in the description of *ūrddha lakṣa* in *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 3.27. The technique described here is identical. The practitioner is to fix the gaze on the sky day and night. Sundardās explains the effect resulting from the practice in similar terms.[17] In 3.27cd Sundardās states: "Various kinds of splendour manifest, the essence of the Gopīs' object of consideration becomes visible." Due to the striking similarity of the formulations and the fact that Sundardās must have been a contemporary of Rāmacandra, a relationship between the passages is plausible. Sundardās was a disciple of Dādū Dayāl (1544–1603) and a member of the school named after him, and therefore a Vaiṣṇava, so the phrase "the essence of the object of the Gopīs' consideration" probably refers to the essence of Kṛṣṇa. Gopīs are paradigmatic figures of devotion (*bhakti*) to Kṛṣṇa.[18] Since Kṛṣṇa is considered the eighth *avatāra* of Viṣṇu, the essence or being of Kṛṣṇa is probably Viṣṇu, who is sometimes called *puruṣottama* or *parameśvara*. Whether the *adṛṣṭaḥ padārthaḥ* of Rāmacandra derives from the *gopi padāratha* is uncertain, but the parallels to the wording of the *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* are striking. Rāmacandra does not seem to favour any sectarian affiliation, and despite the clear Śaiva orientation of the main

[14] *Tattvayogabindu* XV, *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, p. 834) and *Yogakarṇikā* 2.5.

[15] *Tattvayogabindu* XIV (Ed. p. **??**): *etasya lakṣyasya dṛḍhīkaraṇāt parameśvarasya tejasā saha dṛṣṭer aikyaṃ bhavati | atha cākāśamadhye yaḥ kaścid adṛṣṭaḥ padārtho bhavati | sa sādhakasya dṛṣṭigocare bhavati |*

[16] *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā* MMPP MS. No. 2244 f. 124v ll. 1–2.

[17] *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 3.27: *ūrddha lakṣa karai ihīṃ bhāṃtī | duṣṭy ākāśa rahai dina rātī | bibidh prakāra hoi ujiyārā | gopi padāratha dīsahiṃ sārā ‖* 27 *‖*

[18] See e.g. *Bhāgavatapurāṇa* 10.29.

source text of his compilation, he is remarkably neutral in his formulations. Here, once more, he maintains his neutrality.

1.1.1.2 Adholakṣya

The lower focus (*adholakṣya*) as presented in the *Tattvayogabindu* requires the stabilisation of the gaze (*dṛṣṭi*) at a distance of twelve fingers' breadth from the tip of the nose or on the tip of the nose itself. The technique stabilises the gaze and breath and prolongs life.[19,20] Afterwards, the practitioner is instructed to focus inwardly and outwardly on emptiness (*śūnya*), which leads to freedom from the fear of death (*maraṇatrāsa*).[21] Sundaradeva, in his *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā*,[22] quotes the full passage of *Tattvayogabindu*'s *adholakṣya* without attribution. However, the *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā* transmits further techniques in connection with the description of *adholakṣya*:[23]

[19] *Yogasvarodaya* (PT): *nāsikopari deveśi dvādaśāṅgulamānataḥ dṛṣṭiḥ sthirā* (*dṛṣṭisthiran* YK 2.5) *tu karttavyā* (*karttavyam* YK 2.5) *adholakṣam idaṃ bhaja* (*bhajet* YK 2. 5) | *athavā* (*tathā ca* YK 2.5) *nāsikāgre tu sthirā dṛṣṭir iyaṃ bhavet* (*śṛṇu* YK 2. 5) *sthirā dṛṣṭiś cirāyuḥ syāt tathāsau* (*yasya bhavet sthirā dṛṣṭiś cirāyuḥ* YK 2. 6) *sthiradṛṣṭimān* |

[20] Rāmacandra, in contrast to *Yogasvarodaya*, notes at this point that both options are taught as techniques of external focus (*bāhyalakṣya*). The difference for Rāmacandra appears to be not only the designation but, above all, the subsequent focussing on *śūnya*.

[21] Rāmacandra reduces and massively changes his source text; see p. **??**. Rāmacandra's *adholakṣya* on *śūnya* is attributed to *antarlakṣya* in the *Yogasvarodaya*. For a translation of the passage, see p. 13.

[22] I based the collation of the passages of the *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā* on ORI B 220 (f. 239r l. 8 to f. 240r l. 13), GOML R 3239 (f. 258 l. 14 to f. 259 l. 10) and MMPP 2244 (f. 124r ll. 5–9 to f. 125r ll. 1–2).

[23] This passage may represent material composed by Sundaradeva himself, or is derived from an as yet unidentified source.

athavā dṛṣṭir netrayor dvayor netrādhobhāgayor akṣikūṭayos tad adhogallayor ubhayor upari sthirā kartavyā | ekānte vijane dīpam āvarake saṃsthāpya ciraṃ gatvāvalokya stheyam | ghaṭīmātraṃ vā ghaṭikārdhaṃ vā tato dīpam ācchādya bhūmau sarvatrāvalokane sarvaṃ śvetanīlapītasphuliṅgasphuliṅgakaṇānte maṇḍalākārīṇi ceti jyotiścakrāṇi pañca ṣad vā dṛśyante | tataś cāṃdhakāre dṛśyate | dīptimat sarvaṃ svaśarīraṃ dṛśyate | bhāsate sarvo 'pi sapradeśo dīptimān sphuṭo dṛśyate | ekadārḍhye jyotirmayacakrānte parameśvarasya tejomūrtir dṛśyate | puṃsaḥ paramānandotpattir jāyate | svadehavismṛtiś ca saṃbhavati | athavā svanetrayor vartamanīr dakṣahastamadhyamātarjanībhyām akṣikuṭayor adhaḥ kṛtvā akṣivartmanī dṛḍhaṃ cālanī ye ghaṭikārdhaṃ vā ghaṭīmātraṃ tata evaṃ kṛte sādhakasyāgre suśvetajyotiḥ prākāśaḥ prāg bhavatīti |

Alternatively, the gaze should be fixed on the lower parts of both eyes, at the rim of the eye sockets, just above the cheeks. In a secluded place, a lamp shall be placed in a darkened [room] [and] after some time has passed, one should continue looking at it. After one *ghaṭikā* (24 minutes), or half a *ghaṭikā* (12 minutes) [already], having covered the lamp and then, while looking all around on the ground, five or six circles of light appear, which are shaped like *maṇḍala*s and occur amidst white, blue, and yellow sparks.

1–13 Jo = Jodhpur MS. No. 2244; G = Chennai GOML Ms. No. R 3239; G_{pc} = ibid. *post correctionem*; M = Mysore ORI Ms. No. B 220.

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1 dṛṣṭir Jo] dṛṣṭi $GG_{pc}M$ **dvayor** $GG_{pc}M$] dvayo Jo **netrādhobhāgayor** $GG_{pc}M$] netrā 'dhobhāgayor Jo **1–2 adhogallayor** em.] adhogallayo cett. **2 ubhayor** GG_{pc}] rūpayor CJo, rūpa M **upari** GG_{pc}Jo] pari M **āvarake** Jo] āvake $GG_{pc}M$ **3 ghaṭīmātraṃ** $GG_{pc}M$] ghaṭīmātra J **5 °pīta°** Jo] yoṃta M, yomta GG_{pc} **°kaṇānte** MGG_{pc}] °kaṇāṃ 'te Jo **maṇḍalākārīṇi** em.] maṇḍalākāriṇiś cett. **ceti** $GG_{pc}M$] ceta Jo **6 cāṃdhakāre** GG_{pc}Jo] vāṃdhakāre M **8 ekadārḍhye** em.] ekadārḍye G_{pc}, etadārḍye G **9 saṃbhavati** $GG_{pc}M$] saṃbhavati | athavā svanetrayor vartmanīr dakṣahastamadhyamātarjanībhyām akṣikū dehavismṛtiś ca saṃbhavati | Jo **10 vartamanīr** Jo] vartmanā $GG_{pc}M$ **11 akṣikuṭayor** em.] ākṣikoṭayor M, akṣikūṭakūṭayor GG_{pc}, akṣikūtvā Jo **adhaḥ kṛtvā** $GG_{pc}M$] *om.* Jo **akṣivartmanī** $GG_{pc}M$] akṣivanmanī Jo **12 sādhakasyāgre** em.] sādhyakasyāgre GJoM **suśvetajyotiḥ** GJo] suśvītajyotiḥ M **13 prāg** $GG_{pc}M$] prāgvad Jo

> As a result, one is able to see in the dark. One's entire body is seen as luminous. Also, the entire surrounding area appears radiant [and] becomes clearly visible. When one becomes firmly established in one of the circles of light, the luminous form of the supreme lord is seen. Supreme bliss arises for the person. One forgets one's own body.
>
> Alternatively, having placed the thumb and index finger of the right hand below the edge of the eye socket at one's own eyelids, and steadily moving [the fingers] at the eyelids, either for a half *ghaṭikā* (12 minutes) or for a *ghaṭikā* (24 minutes), as a result of having done this, very bright white light becomes visible in front of the practitioner.

Sundardās's *adho lakṣa* is the simple focusing of the gaze on the tip of the nose, which leads to the stabilisation of breath and mind.[24]

1.1.1.3 Bāhyalakṣya

The external focus (*bāhyalaksya*)[25] is the fixation of the gaze (*dṛṣṭi*) on one of the five gross elements at different distances from the tip of the nose or, in one case, directly on the tip of the nose. The texts present the foci as alternatives. The presentation of the three texts follows the same pattern in every case. They list a specific location, followed by an element (in most cases) and a characteristic, such as an associated colour. A table is the best way to illustrate the spread of the various techniques across the texts.

[24] *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 2.26: *prathamahīṃ adho lakṣa kauṃ jānaiṃ | nāśā agra dṛṣṭi sthira ānaiṃ | yātoṃ mana pavanā thira hoī | adho lakṣa jo sādhai koī* ‖ 26 ‖

[25] *Tattvayogabindu* XXIII; *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, p. 837).

Table 1: Foci of Bāhyalakṣya

Location	**Element**	**Characteristic**	***Yogatattva-bindu***	**Yoga-svarodaya**	***Haṭha-saṃketa-candrikā***	***Sarvāṅga-yogapra-dīpikā***
Four finger breadths from the nose	Space	Appearing blue, full of splendour	x[26]	x[27]	x[28]	x
Six finger breadths from the nose	Wind	In the shape of smoke	x	x	-	x
Eight finger breadths from the nose	Fire	Very red	x	x	x	x
Ten finger breadths from the nose	Water	White, fickle	x	-	-	x
Twelve finger breadths from the nose	Earth	Yellow-coloured	x	-	-	x
At the tip of the nose	Space	Full of fire, shining like ten million suns	x	-	-	-
Above the space-element	Space	Connected to the sun without the sun (thousand rays)	x	-	-	-
Seventeen-finger wide distance above the head	Light	Mass of light	x	x	-	-
In front of the gaze	Earth	Appearing in the colour of molten gold	x	x	-	-

[26] A "x"signifies the presence, and a "-" the absense of the focus in the text.
[27] Here, the *Yogasvarodaya* mentions no element.
[28] The *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā* provides the wind as the element and the shape of smoke as the characteristic of this focus.

Table 1 shows that the *Tattvayogabindu* contains the greatest number of foci of the *bāhyalakṣya* category. Sundaradeva does not adopt all the foci in his *Yogasaṃketacandrikā*. However, here, the transmission of this passage appears partially corrupt, since the witnesses mix up the first two foci. The *Yogasvarodaya* only contains five of the nine foci in the table. It therefore seems plausible that Rāmacandra added further foci based on the explanations of Bahirlakṣya in the *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati* 2.28 (Ed. 38–40).[29] Sundardās describes the first five foci for the five elements in a perfectly analogous fashion.[30] In the last verse of his explanation of *bāhya lakṣa*, he explains that there are many more *bāhya lakṣa*s, but they must be revealed by the Guru.[31] The effects attributed to the practice of *bāhyalakṣya* are similar throughout the texts. Regardless of the variant practised, the practice promises rejuvenation, improved health, sometimes even an improved social life[32] and a longer lifespan, among other benefits

1.1.1.4 Antar(a)lakṣya

The inner focus (*antar(a)lakṣya*) is a special case because there are significant differences between Rāmacandra's *Tattvayogabindu* and the *Yogasvarodaya*. Although Rāmacandra continues to follow the *Yogasvarodaya* in terms of structure and content for the description of his *antar(a)lakṣya*, the passages in the *Yogasvarodaya* are not explicitly attributed to *antaralakṣya*, but are evidently assigned to the preceding *bāhyalakṣya*.[33] In addition, Rāmacandra simultaneously uses the *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati* (2.26–27) as a source for this passage, which attributes largely similar practices to the category of *antar(a)lakṣya*. In the *Yogasvarodaya*, there is a separate description of *antarlakṣya*, the core practice of which was already integrated by Rāmacandra in the context of

[29] The *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati* teaches only three instead of five Lakṣyas: *antarlakṣya* (2.26–27); *bahirlakṣya* (2.28); and *madhyalakṣya* (2.29).

[30] *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 2.29–31.

[31] Ibid. 2.32: *bāhya lakṣa aur bahuterī so jānaṃ jo pāvai serī | sataguru kṛpā karai jau kabahī | dei batāi chinak maiṃ sabahī ‖ 32 ‖*

[32] *Tattvayogabindu* XXIII: *samagrāḥ śatravaḥ svapne 'pi mitratām ayānti |*

[33] Cf. *Tattvayogabindu* XXIV and *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, pp. 837–38).

his *adholakṣya*.[34] The concept of the *antar lakṣa* of Sundardās is essentially identical.

In the XXIV section of the *Tattvayogabindu*, Rāmacandra specifies a total of three alternative *antar(a)lakṣya*s. As part of the explanations of the first *antar(a)lakṣya*, Rāmacandra first presents a description of the central channel in the yogic body, which is labelled here as *brahmanāḍī*. It originates at the base of the spinal axis (*brahmadaṇḍa*) and extends through it from bottom to top. The central channel extends from the root-bulb (*mūlakanda*) to the opening of Brahman (*brahmarandhra*) at the top of the head. It is shaped like the stem of a lotus flower and shines like ten million suns. The practice of *antar(a)lakṣya* consists of meditating on it, which allows the practitioner to acquire supernatural abilities. Only the first of the three techniques appears in the context of *antar lakṣa* in the *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* of Sundardās, albeit in less detail. According to Sundardās, one is supposed to meditate on the central channel also called *brahmanāḍī*, which brings about the eight supernatural abilities.[35]

Rāmacandra's second technique for the practice of *antaralakṣya* is a meditation on a bright light above the forehead, which is said to prevent certain diseases.

His third alternative for the practice of *antaralakṣya* is meditation on the very fine red light in the centre between the eyebrows, which causes the yogin to be loved by everyone in the royal court and causes others to be unable to take their eyes off him.[36]

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[34] This is the meditation on emptiness (*śūnya*), cf. *Tattvayogabindu* XV and *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, p. 834).

[35] *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 3.33: *aṃtar lakṣa ju sunahuṃ prakāśā | brahma nāḍikā karahu abhyāsā | aṣṭa siddhi nava niddhi jahāṃlauṃ | ṭarahiṃ na kabahūṃ jivai jahāṃ lauṃ ‖ 33 ‖*

[36] All three techniques of *antar(a)lakṣya* are also specified in the *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, p. 837–838), but still in the context of *bāhyalakṣya*: *mūlakandotthatalato brahmanāḍīsamudbhavā | śvetavarṇā brahmarandhraparyantam eva tiṣṭhati | eṣā tu brahmarandhrākhyā tanmadhye varttate parā | padmatantusamākārā koṭisūryataḍitprabhā | calaty ūrddhaṃ mahāmūrttir asya dhyānād bhavec chivaḥ | aṇimādy aṣṭasiddhis tu samagreṇa prasīdati | lalāṭopari vā dhyātvā candraṃ vā jyotir īśvaram | nāśayet kuṣṭharogādīn mahāyuṣmān śivaḥ paraḥ | bhruvor madhye 'thavā dhyātvā arkan tu teja īśvaram | sthiradṛṣṭau rājapūjyo jīvanmuktaḥ śivo yathā | ātmānam ātmarūpaṃ hi dhyātvā yo niṣkriyo bhavet | nirāśīryatattvo 'yaṃ itaro na nṛpasthitiḥ |*

Interestingly, the *antar(a)lakṣya* of the *Yogasvarodaya*,[37] differs greatly from the models in *Tattvayogabindu*, *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā*, and *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati*. It is exclusively about meditation on emptiness (*śūnya*):

antarlakṣaṃ śṛṇu subhru digvidigādivarjitam |
bāhyābhyantara ākāśaṃ vādhāmantraṃ paraṃ mataṃ ||

Listen to the internal focus, O lovely-browed [Goddess], being devoid of the major and minor directions, etc. The internal and external space is the magical formula against pain, the supreme view.

calajjāgratsuṣupteṣu bhojaneṣu ca sarvadā |
sarvāvasthāsu deveśi cittaṃ śūnye niyojayet ||

While walking, waking, sleeping, and eating, at all times [and] in all states, oh Goddess, the mind shall be focussed onto emptiness.

karttā kārayitā śūnyaṃ mūrtimān śūnya īśvaraḥ |
harṣaśokaghaṭastho 'yaṃ janmamṛtyū labhet svayam ||

The actor and he who causes to act are void; the form-bearer in the void is the supreme lord. Situated in a vessel[38] of joy and sorrow, he himself undergoes birth and death.

ghaṭasthāṃ cintayen mūrtimitaś cintāsvarūpadhṛk |
viṣayaṃ viṣavad dṛṣṭvā tyaktvā jñātvā tu mārutam ||

[37] *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, p. 824) and *Yogakarṇikā* 2.8–13.
[38] Obviously, the human body or body of living beings.

1 PT= *Prāṇatoṣiṇī* quotes *Yogavarodaya* with reference *yogasvarodaye*. YK= *Yogakarṇikā* quotes *Yogavarodaya* with reference *yogasvarodaye*.

1 **subhru°** PT] śukra° YK **2** **bāhyābhyantara ākāśaṃ vādhāmantraṃ paraṃ mataṃ** YK] *om.* PT **5** **śūnyaṃ** YK] śunyaḥ PT **7** **ghaṭasthāṃ** YK] ghaṭasthā PT **cintayen** YK] cintyayor PT **mūrtimitaś** YK] mūrtir hata° PT **8** **dṛṣṭvā** YK] duṣṭaṃ PT

He shall contemplate [himself as] being situated in a vessel, established as form [and] carrying the nature of thought. Having abandoned sense objects as defective like poison, having understood them as consisting of the Maruts, …

saṃjñāśūnyamanā bhūtvā puṇyapāpair na lipyate |
bāhyam ābhyantaraṃ khaṃ yad antarlakṣam iti smṛtam ||

…having become aware of the emptiness of conception, he is not tainted by merit or sin. That which is the inner and outer space is taught as the internal focus.

etaddhyānāt sadā kiñcid duḥkhaṃ na syāc chivo bhavet |
śūnyan tu saccidānandaṃ niḥśabdaṃ brahmaśabditam |
saśabdaṃ jñeyam ākāśam iti bhedadvayan tv iha ||

Because of this meditation, no suffering will arise [and] one would become Śiva. Emptiness is being-consciousness-bliss, [and] called the soundless Brahman; space [on the other hand] is to be understood as with sound. Indeed, this is the twofold distinction here.

1.1.1.5 Madhyalakṣya

The concept of the central focus (*madhyalakṣya*) is very similar in all three texts. In the *Tattvayogabindu*,[39] a light is visualised mentally. The light is supposed to be the size of one's own body. Like a room on fire, the body is to be visualised as filled with light. The light shall be white, yellow, red, grey or blue. The envisioned light is compared to the light of the sun, lightning or a crescent moon. *Madhyalakṣya* leads to the burning of the impurities of the mind. It also produces a sattvic quality of mind. The practitioner becomes

[39] See *Tattvayogabindu* XXVII, Ed. p. **??**.

2 khaṃ PT] *om.* YK **yad** em.] yad hi YK, hi PT **5 ākāśam** PT] ākāśa YK

blissful. Rāmacandra remains very close to his original text regarding the choice of terminology and the content. Thus, there is no significant conceptual difference in comparison with the *madhyalakṣya* of the *Yogasvarodaya*.[40] Sundardās's descriptions in the *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* are shorter, but equally similar. The mind is supposed to dwell in its centre and focus on the form of the body. The practice brings about the sattvic quality of the mind. However, Sundardās does not specify any visualisation of a light.[41]

1.1.2 Lakṣyayoga in the *Yogasiddhāntacandrikā*

Nārāyaṇatīrtha divides Lakṣyayoga neither into five,[42] nor into three subcategories.[43] His explanations are of a more general nature. He locates Lakṣyayoga within the framework of his commentary on *Yogasūtra* 1.35.

> *lakṣyayogasvarūpam upāyāntaram āha—*
> *viṣayavatī vā pravṛttir utpannā manasaḥ sthitinibandhinī* ‖ 35 ‖
>
> It is said [there is] another method having the nature of Lakṣyayoga—Alternatively, when activity directed towards a sense object arises, it causes the mind to become stable.

Nārāyaṇatīrtha explains:

> *viṣayavatīti | nāsāgrādau cittasya saṃyamarūpāl lakṣyayogād divyagandhādisākṣātkāro bhavati | seyaṃ viṣayavatī pravṛttir viśvāsam utpādya parameśvarādāv atisūkṣme manasaḥ sthitiṃ sampādayatīty arthaḥ | tathā ca śāstrīyānubhavaviṣaye jāte śraddhayā yogino dhyānādau sthirā bhavatīty ayaṃ lakṣyayogaḥ |*

[40] Cf. *Yogasvarodaya* (PT, p. 839): *idānīṃ madhyalakṣan tu kathyate siddhikārakam | śvetaṃ raktaṃ tathā pītaṃ dhūmrākāran tu nīlabham | agnijvālāsamānābhā vidyutpuñjasamaprabhā | āditya-maṇḍalākāram athavā candramaṇḍalam | jvaladākāśatulyaṃ vā bhāvayed rūpam ātmanaḥ | etaj jyotirmayaṃ dehaṃ manomadhye tu lakṣayet | eteṣāñ ca kṛte lakṣe nānāduḥkhaṃ praṇaśyati | manasas tu malo yāti mahānando bhavet tataḥ |*

[41] *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā* 3.28: *madhya lakṣa mana madhya bicārai | vapu pramāna koi rūpa nihārai |yāte sātvik upajai āī | madhya lakṣa jo sādhai bhāī* ‖)

[42] As in the *Tattvayogabindu*, the *Yogasvarodaya* or in the *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā*.

[43] As in the *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati* or the *Śivayogapradīpikā*.

yā hi nāsādideśeṣu dṛṣṭiḥ puṃsāṃ sthirā bhavet |
sa lakṣyayoga ākhyāto yoge śraddhākaraḥ paraḥ ||
iti smṛter iti || 35 ||

[Regarding the term] "*viṣayavatī*". As a result of Lakṣyayoga, which has the nature of concentration of the mind (*saṃyama*) on the tip of the nose, etc., a direct perception of divine fragrances and other objects occurs. This activity being directed to sense objects, having produced confidence, produces stability of the mind in [something] very subtle, in [something like] the supreme Lord, etc. Such is the meaning. And thus, stability in meditation, etc., arises for the yogin once confidence has arisen through an experience corresponding to scripture. This is Lakṣyayoga.

For indeed, when the gaze of the person becomes steady at places like the tip of the nose, etc.,
that is called Lakṣyayoga, which is said to inspire supreme confidence in yoga.

Thus, it is remembered.

Nārāyaṇatīrtha is referring to the *bhāṣya*-part of the *Pātañjalayogaśāstra* concerning *sūtra* 1.35.[44] In the *bhāṣya*, various foci for meditation and specific effects that arise through concentration on the respective point are listed. Concentration on the tip of the nose produces direct perception of

[44] *Pātañjalayogaśāstra* (Ed. p. 80): *nāsikāgre dhārayato 'sya yā divyagandhasaṃvit sā gandhapravṛttiḥ | jihvāgre rasasaṃvit | tāluni rūpasaṃvit | jihvāmadhye sparśasaṃvit | jihvāmūle śabdasaṃvid ity etā vṛttaya utpannāś cittaṃ sthitau nibadhnanti, saṃśayaṃ vidhamanti, samādhiprajñāyāṃ ca dvāribhavantīti | etena candrādityagrahamaṇipradīparaśmyādiṣu pravṛttir utpannā viṣayavaty eva veditavyā yady api hi tattacchāstrānumānācāryopadeśair avagatam arthatattvaṃ sadbhūtam eva bhavati | eteṣāṃ yathābhūtārthapratipādanasāmarthyāt, tathāpi yāvad ekadeśo 'pi kaścin na svakaraṇasaṃvedyo bhavati tāvat sarvaṃ parokṣam ivāpavargādiṣu sūkṣmeṣv artheṣu na dṛṃ buddhim utpādayati | tasmāc chāstrānumānācācāryopadeśopodbalanārtham evāvaśyaṃ kaścid arthaviśeṣaḥ pratyakṣīkartavyaḥ | tatra tadupadiṣṭārthaikadeśapratyakṣatve sati sarvaṃ sūkṣmaviṣayam api āpavargāc chraddhīyate | etadartham evedaṃ cittaparikarma nirdiśyate | aniyatāsu vṛttiṣu tadviṣayāyāṃ vaśīkārasaṃjñāyām upajātāyāṃ samarthaṃ syāt tasya tasyārthasya pratyakṣīkaraṇāyeti | tathā ca sati śraddhāvīryasmṛtisamādhayo 'syāpratibandhena bhaviṣyantīti |*

fragrance. Concentration on the tip of the tongue leads to direct perception of taste. Concentration on the palate leads to direct perception of form. Concentration on the centre of the tongue leads to direct perception of touch. Concentration on the root of the tongue leads to direct perception of sound. In addition, the *bhāṣya* lists the moon, sun, planets, jewels and lamps as sensory objects for focussing the mind. The resulting heightened perceptions stabilise the mind, remove doubt and open the way to *samādhi*. Furthermore, the *bhāṣya* explains that although the true nature of reality can be revealed through scriptures, inferences or instructions from teachers, these must be experienced personally, through one's own senses, so that such knowledge does not remain merely indirect. Otherwise, doubt persists for the practitioner. However, if these heightened perceptions referred to in this *sūtra* are experienced personally, then faith, trust or confidence (*śraddhā*) in the statements of the scriptures etc., the entire yogic endeavour and especially the possibility of the desired liberation is strengthened.

1.1.3 Lakṣyayoga in the complex yoga taxonomies

The comparative analysis of Lakṣyayoga across the four early modern yoga taxonomies reveals that these texts are the first to treat Lakṣyayoga as an independent category, even though practices involving *lakṣya*s are considerably older. Earlier sources describe only a threefold scheme (*antar-*, *bahir-* and *madhyalakṣya*), whereas all texts that present Lakṣyayoga as a distinct type adopt the fivefold model (*ūrdhva-*, *adho-*, *bāhya-*, *antara-* and *madhyalakṣya*). Although various texts—such as the *Netratantra*, *Śivayogapradīpikā*, *Maṇḍalabrāhmaṇopaniṣat* and *Advayatārakopaniṣat*—mention three *lakṣya*s, none presents them as a separate yoga. The earliest works to teach Lakṣyayoga as an autonomous yoga category were very likely the *Tattvayogabindu* and the lost *Yogasvarodaya*. From the *Yogasvarodaya*, the category passed into the *Prāṇatoṣinī*, *Yogakarṇikā* and *Tattvayogabindu*, and from the latter into the *Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā*. Nārāyaṇatīrtha's presentation of Lakṣyayoga in the *Yogasiddhāntacandrikā* may be understood as an attempt to integrate this increasingly prominent category into the *Yogasūtra*. In a similar vein, and perhaps in response to its growing prominence, Sundardās appears to have incorporated

Lakṣ(y)ayoga into his *Sarvāṅgayogapradīpikā*. Across the corpus, the conceptual treatment of Lakṣyayoga remains strikingly consistent. Lakṣyayoga thus emerges as a defining category of texts with complex yoga taxonomies.

Chapter 2

Appendix

2.1 Figures



Figure 2: The *dehasvarūpa* of *ajapāgāyatrī*. The image, reminiscent of a hippogriff, is part of an illustrated Sanskrit manuscript written in the Śāradā script. Preserved as a single large scroll under Acc. No. 1334 at the Oriental Institute in Srinagar (Kashmir), it is entitled *Nāḍīcakra*. The manuscript contains a depiction of the yogic body's *cakra*s and *nāḍī*s. The text surrounding the figure closely corresponds to the additional material found in manuscript U_2 of the *Tattvayogabindu*. The manuscript reads (diplomatic transcription): *oṃ daśame pūrṇagiripīṭhe lalāṭamaṇḍale candro devatā amṛtāśaktiḥ paramātmā ṛṣiḥ dvāviṃśaddalāni amṛtavāsinikalā 4: ambikā 1 lambikā 2 gha(ṃ)ṭkā 3 tālikā 4 dehasvarūpaṃ kākamukhaṃ 1 naranetraṃ 2 gośṛṅgaṃ 3 lalāṭabrahmapara 4 hayagrīvā 5 mayūramuścaṃ 6 haṃsacārītani 7 sthāna.*



Figure 3: Viṣṇu Viśvarūpa, India, Rajasthan, Jaipur, ca. 1800–1820, Opaque watercolor and gold on paper, 38.5 × 28 cm, Victoria and Albert Museum, London, Given by Mrs. Gerald Clark.



Figure 4: The Equivalence of Self and Universe (detail), folio 6 from the *Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati* (Bulaki), India, Rajasthan, Jodhpur, 1824 (Samvat 1881), 122 x 46 cm, RJS 2378, Mehragarh Museum Trust.

Chapter 3

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Index

ādhāra, 2
adholakṣya, 2
ākāśa, 2
antaralakṣya, 5
Aṣṭāṅgayoga, 5

bāhyalakṣya, 2
bhakti, 6
bindu, 3
brahmadaṇḍa, 12
brahmanāḍī, 12
brahmarandhra, 12

cakra, 2

Dādū Dayāl, 6
dhvani, 3
Dīkṣottara, 3
dṛṣṭi, 5

Haṭhapradīpikā, 4
Haṭhasaṃketacandrikā, 4
Haṭhatattvakaumudī, 4
Haṭhayoga, 5

kha, 2
Kiraṇatantra, 3
Kṛṣṇa, 6
Kṣemarāja, 2

lakṣya, 2
Lakṣyayoga, 2

madhyalakṣya, 2
Mālinīvijayottaratantra, 3
manas, 6
Maṇḍalabrāhmaṇopaniṣat, 4
mūlakanda, 12

Nārāyaṇatīrtha, 4
Netratantra, 2
Netroddyota, 2
Nityanāthapaddhati, 4

Pātañjalayogaśāstra, 16

Rājayoga, 2

samādhi, 3
saṃyama, 16
Siddhasiddhāntapaddhati, 4
Śivayogapradīpikā, 2
śraddhā, 17
Sundaradeva, 7

Sundardās, 5
śūnya, 7
Svacchandatantra, 4

Tattvayogabindu, 2

ūrdhvalakṣya, 2

Viṣṇu, 6
Vivekamārtaṇḍa, 4
vyoma, 2

Yogacūḍāmaṇyupaniṣad, 4
Yogasūtra, 15